

Giant reptiles

The reptilian form was so successful that reptiles evolved into some of the most incredible animals ever to have lived. Huge ichthyosaurs swam in the seas, followed by giant dinosaurs that stalked the land.



Amphibians

Fish had evolved fins to control their swimming, but some with fleshy fins could waddle onto land. As they evolved lungs to breathe air, they became the first amphibians—distant relatives of today's salamanders and frogs.

Reptiles

Amphibians kept the moist skin of their fishy ancestors and needed to return to water to lay their soft eggs. But some evolved ways to survive for longer on land. They had dry, scaly skin and laid hard-shelled eggs, becoming the first reptiles.



375
mya

Giant land tortoises first appeared a few million years ago.

320
mya

300
mya



Like other early mammals, Morganucodon was probably nocturnal.

Mammals

At the time of the dinosaurs, furry descendants of smaller reptiles were scurrying over the ground and living in burrows. These were evolving into the first mammals: over time, mothers gave birth to live young and nourished them with breast milk.

250
mya

200
mya

Flowers

For millions of years, plants on land reproduced by scattering dustlike spores on the wind or generating seeds in cones. But when the first flowers appeared, the land bloomed with color—and pollinating insects thrived on their sugary nectar.

